Arms

By Bekah Brunstetter

CHARACTERS: *Siamese twins, one month after they have been surgically removed from each other. Sis has no left arm. Sam has no right arm.*

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Twins have a special bond. And if they live their lives physically connected to each other as well, the bond becomes increasingly strong.*

ACTRESS: *There is a social debate surrounding conjoined twins worldwide. Should the twins be separated as early as possible, even if separation would threaten the lives of one or both of the children?*

ACTOR: *Or should no surgical action be taken until the twins are old enough to decide for themselves whether they want to live out their lives conjoined or separately?*

ACTRESS: *After all, Abigail and Brittney Hansel have lived very successfully . . . together . . . conjoined.*

ACTOR: *This short play, Arms by Bekah Brunstetter explores the psychological effects of conjoined twin separation when 1 twin values the independence*

ACTRESS: *. . . and the other twin is suffering from a deep dependency disorder.*

TOGETHER: *Arms by Bekah Brunstetter.*

Late night, a park. Sis, twenty, sits on a bench, playing with a bracelet. She is dressed as Mrs. Claus, badly. She has one arm. From somewhere in the dark, a voice, her brother, Sam.

SAM: *(Offstage.)* Sis? Sis, where you at?

SIS: *(Leaping to her feet, waving.)* Over here! I'm by the jungle gym! *(Sam, twenty, enters. He, too, is missing an arm. He is dressed in Marine camos. He is rushed, freaked out, out of breath.)*

SAM: Where's the fire?

SIS: What fire?

SAM: You sounded real bad on the phone. What's wrong?

SIS: *(Holding out her bracelet)* My bracelet fell off and I can't get it back on.

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SAM: Seriously?

SIS: What? I can't get it back on. I need you to do it.

SAM: I'm meeting you in the park at two AM cause your bracelet fell off?

SIS: I feel funny without it. Can you just help me get it back on?

SAM: Fine. *(He goes to her. Takes her hand. Helps her put it back on. It may involve teeth. They've done it thousands of times before. It takes a minute)*

SIS: Happy Halloween. I like your costume. Camos are cool right now, right? Well that's kind of weird. Kind of ironic, don't you think so? People in the grocery or going to parties dressed like they're ready to shoot somebody. But no, I like it. Looks good. You look like a soldier. *(Pause)* Who drove you here, huh? I don't like you riding around with people. Mom doesn't like it either. She's probably up worrying about us right now. Well not me. Mom thinks I'm in bed. She thinks I went to Mindy's to watch *Dr. Zhivago.*. *(Sam is finally done with the bracelet. He looks at her.)* You haven't said you like my costume yet.

SAM: You're Mrs. Claus every year.

SIS: Mom spent a month making it, I have to wear it at least seven times or she'll be sad. Dad says he likes it when I wear it cause it reminds him Christmas is coming. I don't know, it makes me want to bake pies and knit and hug fat people. So, um, what are you doing? Wanna go home and watch Food Network? Secret Life of Potato Chips?

SAM: I don't live there anymore.

SIS: That doesn't mean you can't *visit.*

SAM: Sis.

SIS: Sam?

SAM: We're not supposed to be doing this.

SIS: Doing what?

SAM: We're supposed to be apart. We're supposed to be starting our own lives and

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learning to live by ourselves. As two different people, separate people. That means not together. It hasn't even been that long. *(Pause)* If we keep meeting up like this because you can't find your hair thing or because you want to know what I want for my birthday, we're never going to get anywhere. You're not even *trying*. OK?

SIS: Your shoe's untied. Come here.

SAM: No.

SIS: Sammy, let me do it. Don't be stupid.

SAM: Don't call me stupid. *(She pats the bench next to her. Reluctantly, he sits next to her. They become one. They tie his shoe. They've done it a thousand times. During:)*

SIS: Hey remember, I almost forgot, remember when we were eight or something like that, and we would play in the creek down there? And remember Mom said never go near the still water because that's where the bacteria was. And then remember, ha. Remember, there was that one time, right over there, we figured out the monkey bars, how we could do it together. We practiced forever like the Olympics and we did it, and everyone watched. And no one laughed. And then we got popsicles.

SAM: I remember.

SIS: And then remember, the fireworks by the baseball field, and we chased them. Every year.

SAM: Yeah, we did.

SIS: I forget how to run.

SAM: You just have to learn again. To do it by yourself.

SIS: But I don't have anyone to talk to.

SAM: Hey, you said you had a date tonight. With Tommy, from the photo center. He seems really nice.

SIS: I don't know. . . . I love you.

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SAM: I love you too. *(She grabs him, embraces him. He responds. It's tender.)*

SIS: What'd you have for dinner?

SAM: Wendy's.

SIS: ME TOO. *(They smile.)*

SIS/SAM: Jr. Bacon Cheeseburger No Mayo Please Biggie Fries Biggie Coke Side Barbeque Sauce.

SIS: So exactly. Why are we apart?

SAM: It's not good for us. It was hard enough to get away from each other. It took forever, it was so hard, and now you wanna put it right back.

SIS: But maybe we were wrong for trying. Maybe we could get back together? The thing is. The thing is. I don't know if I like it. I don't like it anymore, being separated from you. I'm not used to it, and it scares me. A lot. I don't like being alone.

SAM: You just gotta try. You're not trying.

SIS: I was eating strawberries the other day. Big fat ones.

SAM: I don't like strawberries.

SIS: Since when?

SAM: I just realized it last week that I only ate them a lot because you did.

SIS: Don't say that. You love them. Say you love them.

SAM: Just what about them?

SIS: I was eating them, and I found two stuck together, like freak fruit. Two stuck together like us, cause that happens, when stuff is growing, in nature. Things just join together because it's meant to be. And I cried. And I cried more because I was crying. And I couldn't wipe it on your shirt.

SAM: Wipe it on yourself. *(The car bonks.)*

SIS: Come home with me.

SAM: I don't live there anymore. I go to college. I left. You could, too.

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SIS: You go to *community* college, Sam.

SAM: The teachers are really good! They like me! They think I'm smart!

SIS: They feel *sorry* for you! *(Sam starts to go.)* Sam? Sam? I give up. I tried really hard to live not next to you. I told myself over and over how stupid it was to need somebody so bad. I took pictures of us and spit on them. I looked at other people, really looked at them, and tried to see how they were still good, even though they weren't you. I accentuated the positive. Like you said. I didn't call you. Sometimes I don't call you. Even when I want to. I make myself not do it. But I don't feel like it anymore. I give up. Maybe I am insane and maybe I just want to control you and be controlled like you said, or whatever you said, did you say that? But I don't care. I just wanna be back. Sam? OK. You're ignoring me. That's never happened before. This is the first time anyone has ever ignored anybody at all. Don't you miss me? Even a little bit?

SAM: Of course I miss you.

SIS: When the most?

SAM: At night.

SIS: Me too. *(Pause)* Come home?

SAM: I can't. It's just that, um, I'm kind of leaving. *(Pause)* See I kind of joined the army. I kind of did that yesterday. *(Long, Long pause.)*

SIS: But you only have one arm.

SAM: I'm going to do computer stuff in the government. They just need my brain. They think I'm smart. They want my intelligence. They say I'm an army of one!

SIS: But we don't believe in war.

SAM: No, Sis, *you* don't believe in war! And you never gave me one second to figure out whether or not I do! I want to have preferences and I can't do that with you telling what I like all the time! *(Pause)* So I'm going.

SIS: I hate you. I wish you were never born.

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SAM: What?

SIS: Why are you leaving? Do you hate me? It's cause I'm a freak, isn't it? Well guess what. SO ARE YOU.

SAM: No, it's cause I love you! Sis! I don't wanna be dead! Do you wanna die?

SIS: *(Quietly)* No.

SAM: If I slept one more night next to you or had to watch you pee one more time or listened to you pop every bone in your hand, I woulda killed you. I swear to God. It woulda been violent. And I love you, but if I have to help you one more time reach the peanut butter or listen to you explain to me what the comics mean, I will murder myself. If I have to listen to you one more time tell someone how much we love strawberries, I will disappear. I want to be somebody. A me. A one thing. By myself. I love you but you eat me. It's better this way. I'm leaving.

SIS: . . . War is evil!

SAM: War is essential.

SIS: You got that outta the newspaper!

SAM: Your costume is stupid! *(Long pause. Sis cries.)* But it is. Christmas-themed Halloween costumes are just stupid.

SIS: Everywhere I go, everywhere I look, I keep thinking everybody has one arm. I stare at them walking to me and I think, look at that. And then it turns out they have two. It was just the way I was looking at them. Or the way they were walking. But it's always just me. And you. I can't sleep anymore. I haven't been sleeping. Do you care?

SAM: You have to learn to.

SIS: If you go you'll miss my birthday.

SAM: I know I'll miss your **** birthday. It's mine, too.

SIS: I'm going to be twenty-one. I'm going to get drunk and die.

SAM: I gotta go. Go home, OK?

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SIS: No.

SAM: Go home. *(Sis grabs Sam again. He pushes her off)* GO HOME. *(Sam looks at her, lingering, then exits, runs off into the black.)*

SIS: . . . OK. *(Her bracelet falls off. She holds it up, and looks out, sniff)* SAM! SAM! My bracelet fell off! My bracelet fell off I FORGET HOW TO DO IT! SAM!

(Sound of car speeding off Sis collapses, center, holding her wrist. She's quite a mess. She holds her bare side nostalgically. Slowly, Sam re-enters, she can't see him, but he looks at her, longingly. Almost says something, but turns again, and leaves.)

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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